Module IV

Keralam- Upto 12th Century

Learning Objectives

1. Explain the political organisation, administrative structure, and local governance of the Chera Perumal kingdom of Mahodayapuram.
2. Analyse the role of local institutions, taxation, bureaucracy, and military organisation in the decentralised polity of early medieval Kerala.
3. Evaluate the significance of local self-governing institutions such as the *Nagaram*, *Ur*, *Sabha*, and *Kachcham* in the administration of the Chera state.

Part I

Epigraphic Evidences

Epigraphy is the systematic study of inscriptions engraved on durable materials such as stone, metal, pottery, wood, and cave walls. It is an important branch of historical research that examines the language, script, style, and content of inscriptions to reconstruct the political, social, economic, religious, and cultural history of past societies. . Inscriptions are regarded as highly reliable primary sources of historical evidence. Through the analysis and interpretation of inscriptions, epigraphists establish chronologies, verify historical events, and

gain valuable insights into ancient administrative systems, rulers, and everyday life.

Epigraphy is one of the most significant sources for reconstructing the history of Early Medieval Kerala, as inscriptions provide authentic and contemporary evidence that is often unavailable in literary sources. Temple inscriptions, copper plate grants, hero stones, and stone edicts offer valuable information on political authority, land grants, taxation, trade, and local administration. They also shed light on the social structure, religious institutions, and economic activities of different periods in Kerala's history.

The inscriptions of the Cheras constitute an important source for understanding the political, administrative, and cultural history of early and medieval Kerala. The earliest Chera inscriptions were predominantly written in the Tamil-Brahmi script and the Old Tamil language, reflecting the linguistic and cultural milieu of the Sangam period. During the medieval period, the Chera Perumal inscriptions were composed mainly in Vattezhuthu script, often accompanied by Grantha characters for writing Sanskrit words and expressions. These inscriptions illustrate the gradual evolution of language and script in Kerala and provide valuable evidence for the interaction between Tamil, Sanskrit, and the early development of Malayalam.

Vazhappalli Copper Plate

Vazhappally Copper Plate is one of the most important epigraphic records in the history of Kerala. It was issued during the reign of Rajasekhara in the ninth century CE. Written primarily in the Vattezhuthu script with a few Grantha characters, the inscription provides valuable evidence on the administrative and religious practices of the period. The document highlights the close relationship between the Chera rulers and Brahmanical institutions, illustrating the close integration of political and religious authority in early medieval Kerala.

The Vazhappalli Copper Plate was discovered at Vazhappalli, an *upagrama* (sub-settlement) of Thiruvalla *grama*. The inscription consists of a single copper plate engraved on both sides, containing a total of ten lines. It was issued during the twelfth regnal year of the Chera ruler Rajasekhara, who is described by the imperial title *Rajadhiraja Paramesvara Bhattaraka*. Unlike most Chera inscriptions, which traditionally begin with the benedictory phrase *Svasthi Sri*, this inscription opens with the invocation *Namassivaya*, indicating the king's adherence to Shaivism. The inscription also contains a reference to the Roman gold coin *Dinara*, reflecting the continued use of the term in the contemporary monetary system.

The copper plate records the *kachcham* (proceedings) of a joint meeting of the administrative committees of Vazhappalli and Thiruvattuvai, convened under the presidency of the Chera king. The term *kachcham* is derived from the Sanskrit word *kārya*, meaning official proceedings or administrative business, while another term appearing in the inscription, *chavaththai*, is derived from the Sanskrit *vyavasthā*, signifying an established regulation or administrative order. The inscription further stipulates that any individual obstructing the regular performance of the temple's daily services would incur severe social condemnation by being equated with one who has committed the grave moral offence of marrying his own mother. This provision underscores the importance attached to the uninterrupted conduct of temple rituals and the enforcement of religious discipline in early medieval Kerala.

Tharisappalli Copper Plates.

The Tharisappalli Copper Plates, also known as the Kollam Copper Plates, Syrian Christian Copper Plates, and Kottayam Copper Plates, constitute one of the most significant epigraphic records of early medieval Kerala. The charter was issued in 849 CE by Ayyan Adikal Thiruvadikal, the governor of Venad under the Chera

ruler Sthanu Ravi Kulasekhara, in favour of the West Asian Christian merchant Mar Sapir Iso. The grant authorised him to establish the Tharisappalli at Kollam and conferred extensive privileges, tax exemptions, and land grants for its maintenance. The inscription is engraved on eight copper plates **in** Vattezhuthu script**,** with Grantha and Kufic signatures appearing on the final plate, reflecting the cosmopolitan character of medieval Kerala.

The principal objective of the charter was to promote overseas commerce and encourage the settlement of foreign merchant communities at Kollam, one of the most important ports on the Malabar Coast. The inscription records the establishment of a *nagaram* (merchant corporation) by Mar Sapir Iso and grants important commercial privileges to the merchant guilds of Anchuvannam and Manigramam**,** both of which played a vital role in Indian Ocean trade. It also refers to the Arunurruvar**,** indicating the presence of organized merchant bodies that regulated commercial activities. The charter exempts the beneficiaries from several taxes, including labour tax, sales tax, and vehicle tax, thereby promoting commercial expansion and maritime trade.

The Tharisappalli Copper Plates are an important source for reconstructing the socio-economic life of early medieval Kerala. They provide evidence of land grants, the permanent assignment of skilled labourers to the church, and the close relationship between political authority, religious institutions, and commercial enterprises. The inscription demonstrates how rulers encouraged mercantile activity by granting economic privileges to foreign traders while integrating them into the existing administrative framework. The charter thus reflects the growing importance of temple- and church-centred economic institutions in the development of urban and commercial centres.

The inscription also offers valuable insights into the multicultural character of medieval Kerala. It refers to the presence of Christians, Arabs, Jews, and

indigenous merchant groups who were actively engaged in long-distance trade. The privileges granted to Mar Sapir Iso illustrate the acceptance and integration of diverse religious and ethnic communities within Kerala's social structure. Historian M. G. S. Narayanan has described this process as a "cultural symbiosis," emphasizing the coexistence and interaction of different communities within the region's commercial and social life.

The exact meaning of the term Tharisappalli remains a subject of scholarly debate. Some scholars derive *Tharisa* from the Old Syriac word meaning "prayer" or "meditation," interpreting the term as a Christian church or place of worship. Others associate it with the biblical city of Tarshish, suggesting a West Asian connection. Regardless of its precise meaning, the inscription clearly records the establishment of an important Christian institution that functioned not only as a religious centre but also as a focal point of commercial and social activity.

The Tharisappalli Copper Plates possess immense historical and epigraphic significance. They provide evidence for the growth of maritime trade, the activities of merchant guilds, the expansion of foreign settlements, the development of Kollam as an international port, and the policy of religious accommodation pursued by the Chera administration. Consequently, they remain one of the most important primary sources for reconstructing the political economy, social organisation, and commercial networks of early medieval Kerala and the wider Indian Ocean world.

Parthivapuram Copper Plates

The Parthivapuram Copper Plates constitute one of the most important epigraphic records of early medieval South India and provide valuable information on the political, religious, educational, and social institutions of the Ay kingdom. The charter was issued in 866 CE by the Ay ruler Karunandadakkan (c. 857–883 CE).

It records the purchase of land at Uzhakkutivila in the Munchira Sabha in exchange for another plot, on which a Vishnu temple was constructed and consecrated under the name Parthivasekharapuram. The surviving inscription consists of five copper plates, inscribed on both sides in Vattezhuthu script with Grantha characters used for Sanskrit expressions.

The most significant feature of the charter is its detailed account of the establishment of a Salai**,** or Vedic college, attached to the temple. The institution was modelled on the celebrated Kanthalloor Salai, indicating that it followed an established tradition of higher learning in Kerala. The college had ninety-five designated seats (*kalam*)**,** which were distributed among three groups of Brahmins specializing in different Vedic recensions: forty-five seats for the Pavizhiya Charanam, thirty-six seats for the Taittiriya Charanam, and fourteen seats for the Talavakara Charanam. This allocation demonstrates the systematic organization of Vedic education and the patronage extended by the Ay rulers to Brahmanical scholarship.

The inscription also provides detailed information regarding the admission procedures and regulations governing the *Salai*. Admission was highly selective, and Brahmin candidates were required to obtain the approval of five existing members, who certified their competence in Vedic learning, ritual performance, and priestly duties. Applicants were also expected to have completed formal Vedic training (*Othu*) in one of the major South Indian kingdoms, most probably the Chera, Chola, or Pandya territories. Such provisions ensured the maintenance of high academic and religious standards within the institution.

The charter further lays down a comprehensive code of conduct for the students, known as Chattas**.** They were prohibited from engaging in quarrels or acts of violence, carrying weapons within the college, gambling in the temple precincts, leasing temple lands to tenants, or keeping concubines in their residential

quarters. These regulations suggest that the *Chattas* lived under a strict disciplinary code combining religious observance, intellectual training, and moral conduct. Some historians have suggested that they also received military training, reflecting the dual role of Brahmanical institutions in preserving both religious learning and political order. The students enjoyed considerable prestige in society and were honourably referred to as Chattapperumakkal**.**

From a historical perspective, the Parthivapuram Copper Plates are an invaluable source for understanding the functioning of Brahmanical educational institutions, temple administration, land transactions, and the relationship between political authority and religion in early medieval Kerala. The inscription illustrates how temples functioned not merely as centres of worship but also as institutions of education, economic management, and social organization. It also sheds light on the growing influence of Brahmin settlements and the integration of religious institutions into the administrative framework of the Ay kingdom.

The Parthivapuram Copper Plates possess considerable epigraphic significance as they contain the earliest known South Indian inscription to record a specific date according to the Kali Era.

Thiruvalla Copper Plates

The Thiruvalla Copper Plates, popularly known as the Huzur Treasury Plates**,** are among the most important epigraphic records of medieval Kerala. They constitute an invaluable source for understanding the political, economic, social, religious, and administrative history of the region between the tenth and twelfth centuries CE**.** The plates were discovered in the treasury of the Sree Vallabha Temple at Thiruvalla and consist of a collection of forty-three copper plates inscribed in an early form of Malayalam. Although several plates are now missing, the surviving records contain approximately 630 lines of inscription, making them one of the

longest and earliest documentary sources in the Malayalam language. The inscriptions are engraved in Vattezhuthu script**,** with Grantha characters employed for Sanskrit words and expressions.

Unlike royal copper-plate charters issued on a single occasion, the Thiruvalla Copper Plates represent a compilation of records engraved over a period of nearly two centuries. The inscriptions preserve a continuous record of donations, administrative decisions, land transactions, temple regulations, and social customs associated with the Sree Vallabha Temple. They therefore provide a comprehensive picture of the evolution of one of the most influential Brahmanical institutions in medieval Kerala.

The inscriptions record numerous land grants made by rulers, local chiefs, Brahmins, merchants, and private individuals. These landed endowments constituted the principal source of income for the temple and financed the performance of religious rituals, festivals, charitable activities, and the maintenance of the Salai (Vedic college) attached to the temple. The plates also refer to gold donations, illustrating the accumulation of wealth by the temple and its role as an important economic institution. They contain valuable information on the purchase, sale, taxation, and management of land, demonstrating the close relationship between agrarian production and temple administration.

The Thiruvalla Copper Plates provide detailed insights into the administration of the temple and the surrounding Brahmin settlement. They mention various administrative bodies, officers, and assemblies responsible for supervising temple affairs and local governance. The reference to the Muzhikkulam Kachcham is particularly significant, as it illustrates the existence of an organised legal and administrative framework governing Brahmanical institutions in medieval Kerala.

The copper plates contain references to a hospital maintained by the temple, indicating that religious institutions played an important role in public welfare and healthcare. The records also describe religious ceremonies, temple festivals, offerings, ritual specialists, caste groups, occupational communities, personal names, land prices, and patterns of social organisation. It demonstrate the central role of temples in the redistribution of agricultural surplus and the organisation of local resources. They reveal how temples acted as centres of production, storage, credit, and employment while sustaining educational and charitable institutions.

Part II

Archaeology and Temple Architecture

The temple architecture of early medieval Kerala (c. 600–1200 CE) represents one of the most distinctive regional architectural traditions in South India. It emerged through the interaction of indigenous building practices and selected elements borrowed from the Dravidian traditions of the Pallavas, Pandyas, Chalukyas, and Cholas. Rather than being a mere extension of Tamil temple architecture, Kerala developed an independent architectural style adapted to its geographical conditions, climate, locally available building materials, and socio-religious institutions. The growth of temple architecture during this period coincided with the expansion of Brahmin settlements, the consolidation of the Chera Perumal polity, and the increasing importance of temples as centres of religion, education, administration, and economic activity.

Origins and Indigenous Traditions

The origins of Kerala temple architecture can be traced to the region's indigenous architectural heritage. Archaeologists and historians have identified similarities between early medieval temples and earlier megalithic monuments, particularly rock-cut sepulchres. Architectural features such as long entrance passages, ornamented doorways, circumambulatory paths (*pradakshinapatha*), and circular, square, rectangular, and elliptical ground plans indicate continuity with pre-Brahmanical building traditions. Numerous rock-cut shrines in the former Chera and Ay regions, many of which were originally associated with Jainism or Buddhism, were subsequently converted into Hindu temples dedicated to Shiva and Vishnu. These monuments illustrate the gradual adaptation of existing architectural traditions rather than the wholesale introduction of a new temple-building system.

Consequently, the immigrant Brahmin communities that settled in Kerala appear to have relied largely on the expertise of indigenous craftsmen. Although external influences from the Pallavas and Pandyas are evident in certain decorative and structural features, the fundamental character of Kerala temples remained rooted in local building traditions.

Architectural Features

Early medieval Kerala temples display several distinctive architectural characteristics. Most temples are relatively small in scale and consist of a sanctum (*garbhagriha*), a single hall (*mandapa*), and a circumambulatory passage. The sanctum may be square, circular, rectangular, apsidal, or elliptical, reflecting considerable diversity in temple planning. The superstructure is generally crowned by a steeply sloping conical or pyramidal roof, a feature developed in response to Kerala's heavy monsoon rainfall.

Builders extensively used locally available materials such as laterite, granite, timber, clay, and palm leaves. Granite slabs were employed for foundations, laterite blocks for walls, while timber was used for pillars, beams, ceilings, and roof structures. The extensive use of wood reflects the remarkable skill of Kerala's craftsmen in carpentry and wood carving. Sophisticated iron tools enabled artisans to achieve precision in stone dressing and timber construction.

Royal patronage played a decisive role in the expansion of temple architecture. Chera Perumal rulers, the Ay kings, local chiefs, Brahmin assemblies, merchant guilds, and wealthy individuals contributed land, wealth, and labour for temple construction and maintenance. Consequently, temples became important centres around which agrarian settlements and commercial activities developed.

H. Sankar's Interpretation of the Evolution of Kerala Temple Architecture

Historian and archaeologist **H. Sankar** proposed a three-phase model for the evolution of Kerala temple architecture based on architectural evidence and temple inscriptions.

1. Early Phase (c. 800–1000 CE)

According to Sankar, the earliest surviving temples belong to the period between the ninth and tenth centuries. These temples generally exhibit square, circular, and apsidal plans and represent the formative stage of Kerala temple architecture. Their relatively simple layouts indicate the gradual emergence of an independent regional style.

2. Middle Phase (c. 1001–1300 CE)

The middle phase witnessed the full development of the Kerala style under the Chera Perumal rulers. Temples of this period display greater architectural diversity, including square, circular, rectangular, apsidal, and elliptical sanctums. Inscriptions frequently refer to circular and elliptical temples as Mukkalvattam. Temple construction expanded significantly due to increased royal patronage, the prosperity of Brahmin settlements, and the spread of the Saiva and Vaishnava Bhakti movements.

3. Late Phase (c. 1301–1800 CE)

The final phase comprises temples constructed or substantially renovated after the thirteenth century. Although earlier architectural traditions continued, temples became increasingly elaborate through additions such as larger *mandapas*, *gopurams*, *chuttambalams*, and extensive mural decoration.

Reassessment of H. Sankar's Theory

While H. Sankar's chronological classification provides a useful framework for understanding Kerala temple architecture, many historians argue that inscriptions do not indicate major structural transformations between the early and middle phases. Instead, they reveal changes in temple patronage, religious practices, and institutional organisation. The spread of Bhakti traditions led to the assimilation of local cults into Brahmanical Hinduism. For example, local mother-goddess cults, including the Saptamatrikas, were gradually incorporated into the Saiva and Vaishnava religious systems, often as consorts of major deities. Similarly, temples increasingly became centres of economic management and political authority through extensive land grants and royal patronage.

Several scholars therefore suggest that the origins of Kerala's distinctive temple architecture may extend back to the sixth or seventh century CE, well before the period proposed by Sankar. The rock-cut shrines of the Chera and Ay regions,

together with megalithic architectural traditions, indicate that the foundations of Kerala's temple architecture were laid long before the flourishing of the Chera Perumal state.

Cheraman Parambu

Cheraman Parambu is considered to be the centre of the Chera Dynasty. Located at Kodungallur in the present-day Thrissur district, the site is traditionally identified as the location of the royal palace of the Chera Perumal rulers. Although literary traditions and local legends have long associated the site with the Chera kings, archaeological investigations have provided substantial evidence indicating that Cheraman Parambu functioned as an important political, administrative, and elite residential centre during the Early Medieval period.

Archaeological excavations conducted by the Kerala Council for Historical Research (KCHR) and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) have unearthed a rich assemblage of material remains from Cheraman Parambu. The excavation took place between 1944 and 1945 and identified some pottery associated with the Song Dynasty in China. The excavation unearthed structural foundations built with laterite blocks and bricks, terracotta roof tiles, brick pavements, iron objects, copper artefacts, beads of semi-precious stones, glass bangles, pottery, and Chinese as well as West Asian ceramics. The recovery of imported ceramics such as Chinese celadon and porcelain, along with glazed ware from West Asia, demonstrates the participation of the Chera capital in the extensive Indian Ocean trade network.

According to the excavations led by K. V. Raman, the earliest archaeological remains discovered at the site belong to the eighth–ninth centuries CE. Scholars such as M.G.S. Narayanan consider Cheraman Parambu an important archaeological confirmation of the political organization of the Chera Perumal

state centred at Mahodayapuram. According to Narayanan, the site provides material evidence for the existence of a centralized royal establishment that worked in close collaboration with Brahmin settlements and temple institutions. M.R. Raghava Varier argues that the archaeological remains illustrate the growth of urbanization in medieval Kerala, where royal authority, commercial expansion, and temple-centred socio-economic institutions evolved simultaneously**.** P.J. Cherian and other archaeologists associated with the Pattanam and Kodungallur excavations emphasize that Cheraman Parambu should be understood within the broader archaeological landscape of Kodungallur, which includes ports, temples, settlements, and trade centres interconnected through political and commercial networks.

Mathilakam

Mathilakam**,** located near Kodungallur in the Thrissur district of Kerala, is widely identified as the site of the ancient Thirukkunavay Śiva Temple, an important religious centre of Early Medieval Kerala. The temple is mentioned in Tamil Śaiva devotional literature (Tēvāram) as early as the seventh century CE, attesting to its antiquity and religious significance. Literary traditions also associate the site with Ilamko Atikal (Ilango Adigal)**,** the reputed author of the Tamil epic *Cilappatikāram*, who is believed to have been connected with a monastic establishment at Thirukkunavay. Several scholars further suggest that the locality was the site of the Thirukkunavay Jaina Vihāra, also referred to as Kunavayir Kottam**,** indicating that Mathilakam may have been an important centre of Jainism before its association with Śaivism.

Archaeological excavations have provided substantial material evidence supporting the historical importance of the site. The discovery of massive laterite walls suggests the existence of a large temple or monastic complex. Other significant finds include Red Ware pottery, Chinese celadon ware, and Chola

coins**,** which date the principal phase of occupation to the tenth–eleventh centuries CE. Excavations directed by K. V. Raman have further established that the earliest cultural remains at Mathilakam belong to the eighth–ninth centuries CE, indicating that the settlement predates the structural remains of the medieval temple complex. The recovery of Chola coins and the early occupational levels have led scholars to propose that the site may originally have functioned as **a** Jain religious establishment**,** which was subsequently transformed into a Hindu temple during the later medieval period. Although this hypothesis requires further archaeological verification, the cumulative evidence from recent excavations, together with earlier discoveries of monumental laterite structures and imported artefacts, points to the gradual evolution of Mathilakam as a major religious centre. Consequently, the site provides valuable insights into the religious transformations of Early Medieval Kerala and offers important evidence for understanding the transition from Jain to Brahmanical traditions within the broader context of the region's social, political, and cultural history.

Part III

Formation of Nadu

In early medieval South India, the *nadu* constituted the fundamental unit of society, economy, and administration. These territorial units developed around clusters of agrarian settlements and functioned as the principal framework of local governance. Historians Rajan Gurukkal and M.R. Raghava Varier argue that the emergence of *nadus* was closely associated with the expansion of wet-rice cultivation in the river valleys of Kerala. Although each *nadu* supported a variety of agricultural activities, paddy cultivation formed the economic core of these regions. The agrarian surplus generated by rice production sustained temple

institutions, financed ritual activities, and contributed significantly to the wealth of the landed elite and other privileged social groups.

Inscriptions of the Chera kingdom indicate that its territory was divided into several *nadus*, a term widely used throughout South India and broadly comparable to the Sanskrit word *rāṣṭra*, meaning "country" or "region." It is generally believed that many *nadus* existed before the emergence of the Chera state and were subsequently incorporated into the kingdom during the process of state formation in the ninth century CE. The rulers of these territorial units are referred to in Chera inscriptions by titles such as *Nāḍu Udaiyavar*, *Nāḍu Vāzhunnavar*, and *Nāḍuvāzhi*. However, the inscriptions do not define the territorial boundaries of individual *nadus*, making it difficult to determine their precise geographical extent or relative size. At the height of the Chera kingdom, there were fourteen *nadus*. They were Kolathunadu, Purakkizhanadu, Kurumbranadu, Ramavalanadu, Eralanadu, Valluvanadu, Netumpurainadu, Netumkalainadu, Kalkkarainadu, Vempalanadu, Keezhmalainadu, Venadu, Munhinadu and Nanruzhainadu. Scholars generally agree that the Chera state emerged gradually over nearly two centuries, eventually incorporating most of the territorial divisions corresponding to present-day Kerala.

The political organisation of the *nadus* was not uniform. Some were governed by hereditary chiefs whose authority passed from one generation to another, while others were administered by officials appointed by the Chera rulers. Most *nadus* belonged to the hereditary category. The appointed administrative units appear to have been created primarily for the convenience of Chera governance and disappeared with the decline of the Chera Perumal kingdom centred at Mahodayapuram. In contrast, many hereditary *nadus* continued to exist even after the collapse of Chera political authority.

Each *nadu* maintained its own military force for defence, generally referred to as the *Nāṭṭuvar*. The numerical designation associated with these forces appears to have varied according to the size and importance of the *nadu*. Inscriptions refer to military units such as *Ezhunnūṟṟuvar*, *Arunnūṟṟuvar*, *Ainnūṟṟuvar*, and *Munnūṟṟuvar*, suggesting variations in the strength and organisation of these militias.

The status of the *Nāḍuvāzhis* has been the subject of considerable historiographical debate. M.G.S. Narayanan interprets them as governors appointed by the Chera rulers to administer territorial districts. Kesavan Veluthat, however, argues that they were originally autonomous local chiefs whose authority predated the emergence of the Chera state and who were subsequently incorporated into the expanding political structure of the kingdom. According to this interpretation, the Chera polity was formed through the integration of pre-existing local power centres rather than through the creation of entirely new administrative institutions.

Each *nadu* possessed an administrative assembly or court modelled on the royal court of the Cheras at Mahodayapuram. This body included the *Nāḍuvāzhi*, military commanders, and representatives of influential merchant guilds such as *Anchuvannam* and *Manigramam*. It also comprised the heads of the *ūr* and *paratai* assemblies, together with other important local functionaries, including the chief smith, who frequently acted as a scribe, revenue official, and administrator. The composition of these institutions reflects the close interaction between political authority, military organisation, mercantile interests, and local self-governing bodies in the administration of early medieval Kerala.

Historicity of Mushikavamsakavyam

The *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* is one of the most important literary sources for reconstructing the political and cultural history of medieval Kerala, particularly the history of the Mushaka (Kolathiri) dynasty that ruled the northern Malabar region. Composed in Sanskrit by the poet Atula, generally assigned to the eleventh century CE, the work belongs to the genre of *vamsakāvya* (dynastic court epic), a literary tradition intended to celebrate the genealogy, achievements, and legitimacy of ruling families.

The *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* traces the genealogy of the Mushaka rulers from mythical origins to the reign of its contemporary ruler. Like many dynastic chronicles in early medieval India, it begins by associating the ruling family with sacred legends and divine ancestry. The *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* combines mythical traditions with historical narratives, tracing the genealogy of the Mushaka dynasty from its legendary founder, Rāmaghaṭa Mūṣika, to Śrīkaṇṭha, the patron of the poet Atula. The text presents the genealogy of approximately 115 rulers, thereby offering a continuous dynastic tradition. The first section of the poem is predominantly legendary, narrating the mythical origins of the dynasty through conventional themes and literary motifs characteristic of Sanskrit *mahākāvya* literature. Rather than providing a factual historical account, this portion seeks to establish the divine legitimacy and antiquity of the ruling family.

The second section shifts towards a more structured dynastic narrative by tracing the succession of ninety-seven rulers descended from the founder's son, Nandana. It associates these rulers with the establishment and patronage of several ancient Śaiva temples, including those at Chellur, Ahiraṇeśvara, Kharavaṇa, and Vaṭukeśvara. Although this section continues to incorporate legendary elements, it reflects the increasing importance of temple patronage in legitimising political authority and consolidating regional power.

The third and fourth sections of the *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* are generally regarded by historians as possessing greater historical reliability. These portions describe the reigns of nineteen Mushaka rulers who governed between the ninth and twelfth centuries CE. The historical authenticity of these rulers is supported by inscriptional evidence discovered in temples across northern Kerala, many of which record royal measures undertaken to protect temple properties and regulate their administration. The convergence of literary and epigraphic evidence enhances the credibility of these later sections of the text.

The poem also provides valuable insights into the economic and commercial activities of the Mushaka kingdom. It attributes to the Mushaka rulers an important role in the establishment and development of coastal trading centres such as Marahi (identified with present-day Madayi) and Valabhapattana (modern Valapattanam), indicating the significance of maritime trade in the regional economy. Furthermore, the *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* portrays the Mushaka kingdom as a region characterised by the peaceful coexistence of diverse religious traditions. Its references to the patronage of different religious sects suggest an atmosphere of religious pluralism and demonstrate the rulers' role in fostering social and cultural harmony within their realm.

The historicity of the *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* has been the subject of considerable scholarly debate. Historians generally agree that the text cannot be treated as a straightforward historical chronicle because it was composed as a court epic intended to glorify the ruling dynasty. modern historians recognise that the later sections of the text contain substantial historical material. M.G.S. Narayanan argues that while the mythical portions reflect dynastic ideology, the descriptions of political events, administrative institutions, and regional geography preserve valuable historical traditions that can be corroborated through inscriptions and other contemporary sources. Kesavan Veluthat similarly emphasises that the *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* should be read as a political document expressing the

aspirations of an emerging regional state rather than as a literal historical narrative. Rajan Gurukkal also points out that the text illustrates the process of state formation, Brahmanical legitimisation, and the integration of local chiefdoms into larger political structures in early medieval Kerala.

The historical reliability of the *Mūṣakavamsakāvya* is strengthened when its evidence is compared with inscriptions, copper plate grants, temple records, and archaeological findings. Several rulers, place names, and political developments mentioned in the text correspond broadly with inscriptional evidence from the Chera Perumal period. Such corroboration enables historians to distinguish historically reliable information from literary embellishment. However, chronological inconsistencies, exaggerated military victories, and idealised portrayals of kings require careful critical evaluation before the text can be used as historical evidence.

Kolathunadu

Kolathunadu was one of the most important territorial divisions (*nadus*) of early medieval Kerala and emerged as a significant political, economic, and maritime centre on the northern Malabar Coast. Situated in the region corresponding largely to the present-day Kannur and Kasaragod districts of Kerala, Kolathunadu occupied a strategic position along the Arabian Sea and controlled several important ports that connected the Malabar Coast with the wider Indian Ocean trading network. Throughout the early medieval period, particularly between the ninth and twelfth centuries CE, Kolathunadu played a crucial role in the political history of Kerala under the Chera Perumal kingdom and subsequently developed into an independent regional polity under the Kolathiri rulers.

Although Kolathunadu is not explicitly mentioned by name in the Chera inscriptions, epigraphic evidence from the region clearly indicates the influence

and authority of the Chera rulers. An inscription from Ezhimala near Kannur records the exercise of Muzhikkulam's authority in Kolathunadu during the reign of the Chera king Vīra Kerala Vikrama Rama. Another inscription issued during the reign of Bhaskara Ravi, discovered at Eramam, suggests that Kandan Kari Varma, the ruler of Kolathunadu, acknowledged the suzerainty of the Chera monarch. The Mushika dynasty, which controlled an extensive territory and possessed a long-established political tradition, appears to have occupied a distinctive position among the Nadu chiefs under the Chera political system.

Kolathunadu possessed a well-developed administrative structure typical of early medieval Kerala. The *Nāḍuvāzhi*, or ruler of the *nadu*, exercised authority with the assistance of local assemblies, military commanders, Brahmanical elites, and merchant guilds. Temples functioned not only as centres of religious worship but also as institutions of economic management, land administration, and social integration. The close relationship between political authority and Brahmanical institutions strengthened the legitimacy of the ruling dynasty and facilitated the expansion of agrarian production.

The economy of Kolathunadu was based primarily on agriculture and maritime commerce. The fertile river valleys supported extensive paddy cultivation, while the region's forests yielded valuable products such as timber, spices, and medicinal plants. Its strategic location on the Arabian Sea enabled the development of major ports, including Madayi (Marahi) and Valapattanam (Valabhapattana), which served as important centres of overseas trade. Merchants from Arabia, Persia, and other parts of the Indian Ocean frequented these ports, exchanging pepper, coconut products, timber, ivory, and textiles for horses, metals, luxury goods, and other imported commodities. The presence of merchant corporations such as the *Manigramam* and *Anchuvannam* further demonstrates the commercial importance of Kolathunadu.

Religious and cultural life in Kolathunadu reflected the pluralistic character of early medieval Kerala. Although the Mushaka rulers were predominantly patrons of Brahmanical Hinduism, particularly Śaivism, literary and inscriptional sources indicate the coexistence of Buddhist, Jain, and other religious traditions.

The decline of the Chera Perumal kingdom during the twelfth century CE transformed the political landscape of Kerala. In northern Kerala, the descendants of the Mushaka rulers emerged as the Kolathiri dynasty, establishing an independent kingdom that became one of the most powerful political entities on the Malabar Coast. The Kolathiri state continued to control important ports and inland trade routes, preserving the political and commercial legacy of the earlier Mushaka kingdom.

Eranadu

Eranadu was originally an important *nadu* within the Chera kingdom between the ninth and twelfth centuries CE. According to William Logan, the name *Eranadu* is derived from *Eralanadu*, meaning "the land of cattle," which was ruled by a lineage known as the Eradis. The provincial capital of Eranadu was located at Nediyiruppu, near present-day Kondotty in Malappuram.

The earliest known reference to Eralanadu, the historical name of present-day Eranadu, occurs in the Jewish Copper Plate charter issued during the reign of Bhaskara Ravi. In this inscription, the chief of Eranadu, *Eralanadutaiya Manavepala Manaviyan*, appears as a witness, indicating that *Eralanadutaiya* functioned as a hereditary title of the ruling lineage. This title reappears in an inscription from Thrichambaram, generally assigned to the eleventh century CE.

Another inscription from Pulpatta, near Manjeri, refers to the *Arunnurruvar* (the Six Hundred) of Eranadu. Historians interpret this military organisation as evidence that Eranadu was comparable in territorial extent and administrative importance to other major *nadus*, such as Ramavalanadu, Valluvanadu, and Venadu. Further evidence is provided by the Kollam Rameswaram Temple inscription of Rama Varma Kulasekhara, which mentions the *Utaiyavar* of Eranadu, thereby reaffirming its status as a *nadu* within the Chera political order.

Following the decline of the Chera kingdom, Eranadu emerged as an independent political entity. In the subsequent period, the Eradis expanded their territorial authority westwards and shifted their capital to Kozhikode (Calicut). Over time, the Eradi rulers became widely known as the Zamorins (*Samoothiris*), who later established one of the most influential kingdoms on the Malabar Coast. Although direct evidence regarding the internal administration, economy, and social organisation of Eranadu remains limited, the existence of a hereditary ruling family and a well-defined military organisation suggests that the region enjoyed a considerable degree of autonomy while functioning within the broader framework of the Chera state.

Venadu

Venadu traces its origins to the ancient Vel chieftains, a ruling lineage with deep roots in South India. The name *Venadu* is generally believed to have been derived from the Tamil word *Vel*, meaning "the land of the Vels." During the eighth and ninth centuries CE, Venadu functioned as an autonomous *nadu* within the Chera kingdom. Governed by hereditary rulers, it occupied an important position in the political and administrative structure of the Chera state.

Venadu's rise to prominence was facilitated by several political and economic factors. The port city of Kollam emerged as one of the principal centres of

international maritime trade during the Chera period, attracting merchant communities such as the Syrian Christians, Jewish traders, and the commercial guilds of *Manigramam* and *Anjuvannam*. Their commercial activities significantly contributed to the prosperity of the region. The Tharisappalli Copper Plates issued by Ayyanadikal Thiruvadikal provide valuable evidence for the hereditary leadership of Venadu, referring to Rama Thiruvadikal as the junior prince. This inscription indicates the existence of a local ruling family that functioned under the suzerainty of the Chera monarch.

Another important factor in the growth of Venadu was the strength of its regional leadership. The Mampally Copper Plates (974 CE) mention Sri Vallavan Kotha Varma, the governor of Venadu, who made a grant of land to a temple. This record highlights the active role played by the rulers of Venadu in supporting religious institutions and maintaining local administration. Inscriptions also refer to the Panankavil Palace at Kollam, which had developed into an established centre of political authority. The existence of such an administrative centre suggests that Venadu possessed a well-defined political structure and enjoyed a considerable degree of autonomy within the Chera kingdom. By the twelfth century, with the decline of the Chera Empire, Venadu gradually asserted its independence, laying the foundation for its emergence as one of the most powerful kingdoms in the later history of Kerala.

Part IV

Land rights and relations

Land ownership in Early Medieval Kerala (eighth to twelfth centuries CE) reflected a complex network of political authority, religious patronage, and agrarian relations. The system was characterised by multiple categories of landholding, each associated with specific rights and obligations. Important forms

of land tenure included *Cherikkal*, *Brahmasvam*, *Devasvam*, and *Karanmai*, which together shaped the distribution of land and resources within society. An examination of these institutions provides valuable insights into the relationship between the state, Brahmanical establishments, temples, and the agrarian population in Early Medieval Kerala.

At the apex of the landholding hierarchy stood the Perumal, the Chera king, whose personal estates were known as *Cherikkal* lands. These royal estates were organised through a well-defined agrarian hierarchy. The *Karalar* functioned as tenants who cultivated the land, while the *Kutiyalar* served as occupants or sub-tenants under them. At the lowest level were the *Atiyalar*, who constituted the labouring class attached to the land. Even when portions of *Cherikkal* land were granted as *Viruthi* (service tenure) to temples, Brahmins, or royal officials in recognition of their services, the fundamental relationship between the *Karalar*, *Kutiyalar*, and *Atiyalar* continued to govern agricultural production.

A similar pattern of land administration existed in territories governed by local chieftains (*Nadu Utaiyavars*). These rulers also possessed *Cherikkal* lands and made *Viruthi* grants to religious institutions and officials, thereby reproducing the same hierarchical agrarian structure found in the royal domain. Nevertheless, the landholding system was not confined to a simple relationship between the king or local chiefs and the peasantry. An important intermediate layer emerged through the Brahmin settlements (*Brahmadeyas*), which exercised considerable control over land and local administration. Within these settlements, land was broadly classified into two categories: *Brahmasvam*, referring to land granted to Brahmins, and *Devasvam*, denoting land dedicated to temples. These forms of landholding strengthened the economic foundations of Brahmanical institutions and played a crucial role in shaping the social, religious, and political landscape of Early Medieval Kerala.

Cherikkal Lands

The term *Cherikkal* oc curs frequently in the inscriptions of the Chera period and has been the subject of considerable scholarly debate. Early interpretations offered by historians such as T. A. Gopinatha Rao and M. G. S. Narayanan proposed different explanations for the nature of *Cherikkal* lands. Gopinatha Rao associated the term with lands situated on hill slopes, while other scholars interpreted it as the private domain of the Chera rulers. K. V. Krishna Ayyar equated *Cherikkal* with Crown lands. Although these interpretations provide important insights, recent studies suggest that *Cherikkal* represented a more complex institution than merely royal estates.

Current scholarship indicates that *Cherikkals* were ordinary villages owned by members of the royal family, including kings, governors, queens, and princesses, and were sometimes placed under the administrative protection of neighbouring Brahmin settlements. The term *cheri* originally denoted a hamlet inhabited by the lower social groups, implying that *Cherikkal* referred to non-Brahmin settlements that were distinct from the *Brahmadeya* villages. This distinction reflects the hierarchical organisation of land ownership and settlement patterns in Early Medieval Kerala.

The Chera inscriptions further suggest that all land was theoretically regarded as belonging to the king. The *Nadu Utaiyavars*, functioning as subordinate rulers, exercised authority over the lands within their respective *nadus* and enjoyed the income derived from them in return for paying tribute to the Chera monarch. These inhabited and cultivated villages were designated as *Cherikkals*. Although detailed information regarding everyday life in these royal villages is limited, an inscription recording a dispute between the Chera queen, Cheraman Mahadeviyar, and the Avattiputhur Temple provides valuable evidence regarding their administration. The record indicates that the authorities of the *Cherikkal*

possessed the right to collect various taxes from the inhabitants, including *Kutimai* (house tax) and *Thandam* (judicial fines).

Revenue generated from *Cherikkal* lands also included *Rakshabhoga*, a protection levy that appears to have constituted an important source of income for the assemblies of neighbouring Brahmin settlements. This arrangement contributed to the growing concentration of wealth and influence in Brahmin corporate institutions. In addition, the taxes and revenues collected from *Cherikkal* lands formed a substantial component of the fiscal resources of the Chera state. The placement of a *Cherikkal* as a *Kizhitu* (subordinate property) under the supervision of a Brahmin settlement suggests a system of shared administration, whereby the Brahmin assembly exercised certain administrative and fiscal responsibilities without possessing absolute authority over the land. The Perumal and the *Nadu Utaiyavars* continued to retain ultimate political control over these royal estates. Nevertheless, the precise nature of this relationship and the rights enjoyed by the inhabitants of *Cherikkal* villages remain subjects for further historical investigation.

Brahmasvam

The categories of *Brahmasvam* and *Devasvam* constituted two of the most significant forms of landholding in Early Medieval Kerala. The earliest known epigraphic references to these terms occur in the Porangattiri inscriptions. *Brahmasvam* referred to lands that were granted as the exclusive property of Brahmins, while *Devasvam* denoted lands dedicated to temples for their maintenance and ritual functions. Although these categories were legally distinct, inscriptional evidence indicates that Brahmins frequently exercised control over both *Brahmasvam* and *Devasvam* lands. The concentration of extensive landed property in the hands of Brahmins considerably enhanced their economic resources and strengthened their social and political influence during the period.

The agrarian structure associated with these landholding systems reflected a clear social hierarchy. Brahmin proprietors of *Brahmasvam* lands and managers of *Devasvam* estates generally constituted a non-cultivating landholding class, while agricultural production was carried out by tenants and labourers. Evidence from the Kilimanur inscription suggests that *Karanmai* tenancy rights were sometimes assigned to dependent cultivators and even to bonded labourers, indicating the existence of a layered system of tenancy and subletting. Over time, the gradual decline in the direct control exercised by temple councils over *Devasvam* lands appears to have facilitated the transfer of certain temple properties into the hands of individual Brahmins, thereby reducing the distinction between *Devasvam* and *Brahmasvam* holdings.

Several inscriptions, including the Kollur Mutt Copper Plates, provide valuable information regarding the relationship between temples, Brahmins, and land ownership in Early Medieval Kerala. These records reveal that lands were assigned to temples for meeting various institutional requirements, including the performance of rituals, the celebration of festivals, the maintenance of temple establishments, and the remuneration of temple officials. At the same time, a portion of the land was recognised as the private property of the Brahmin families residing in the vicinity of the temple. The Kilimanur inscription of 1168 CE records that ten Brahmins from established Brahmin settlements were invited to South Kerala and settled around the newly constructed Thiruppalkkadal Temple. They were granted both private landed estates and the authority to administer the temple lands. Similarly, the Thiruvattar inscription of 1020 CE records the settlement of twenty-four Brahmins from Central Kerala for the management of a newly established temple and its landed endowments. In addition to their administrative responsibilities, these Brahmins received private property with hereditary rights of succession.

These inscriptions demonstrate that the distinction between temple property and private Brahmin ownership was often fluid. While individual Brahmins exercised independent rights over their privately held *Brahmasvam* lands, the administration of *Devasvam* lands and temple affairs was generally undertaken collectively by the resident Brahmin community. This close association between Brahmin settlements and temple administration contributed to the consolidation of Brahmin authority and facilitated the accumulation of wealth through both religious and agrarian institutions.

Devasvam

Early Medieval Kerala witnessed the development of *Devasvam* as a distinct category of landholding associated with temples. *Devasvam* lands were the exclusive property of temples and were generally endowed with permanent and inalienable rights. Although these lands legally belonged to the temple, their administration was seldom undertaken directly by the temple institution. Instead, the responsibility for managing temple property rested with the *Uralar*, a corporate body composed of one male representative from each Brahmin household of the settlement. This assembly supervised the administration of temple lands, regulated their cultivation, and ensured that the income generated was utilised for religious and institutional purposes.

The transfer of land to temples was accompanied by formal legal and ritual procedures. Several inscriptions, including the Tharisappalli Copper Plates, describe the ceremonies associated with land grants. These rituals often involved symbolic acts such as the pouring of water (*jaladāna*) to signify the transfer of ownership. In certain cases, particularly in the demarcation of land boundaries, a female elephant was ceremonially led around the granted property. Such rituals served to legitimise the transfer of ownership and publicly affirm the rights of the recipient institution. In some instances, rulers granted lands to the *Uralar* under

Uranmai rights, while *Devasvam* and *Brahmasvam* lands together represented important forms of charitable and religious endowments.

Devasvam lands were generally acquired through royal grants and private donations, as evidenced by inscriptions from Thrippunithura and Pudukkottai. These lands were usually leased for cultivation under *Karanmai* tenancy arrangements, either directly by the temple authorities or through intermediaries holding subordinate rights. The management of temple property was carefully organised, and the responsibilities associated with *Devasvam* lands were distributed among the *Uralar* families. Each family's allotted share of administrative responsibility was known as *Patakara*. This system ensured the collective management of temple resources while maintaining the institutional integrity of the temple establishment.

The inscriptions further indicate that ultimate ownership of all land was theoretically vested in the sovereign, although intermediate rights of control and administration were recognised. This principle is reflected in the use of the term *Itaiyitu* (intermediate ownership) in several records. The *Uralar* were responsible for paying the taxes due on the lands under their administration, and failure to discharge these obligations could result in the forfeiture of their rights. Royal grants occasionally placed a smaller estate, known as *Kizhitu* (subordinate property), under the authority of a temple corporation. One inscription records that the *Devasvam* and *Brahmasvam* lands of Thirumunnur were entrusted to the *Arunnurruvar* and the *Uralar* council, accompanied by a prescribed ritual requiring the offering of lamps to the temple.

Kerala inscriptions also reveal the existence of safeguards designed to protect temple property from misuse by members of the *Uralar*. These regulations prohibited individual Brahmin members or their representatives from interfering with cultivation, appropriating tenants' property, or exploiting temple lands for

personal benefit. Such measures were intended to preserve the economic stability of the temple and protect the interests of its cultivators. The *Uralar* were likewise forbidden from mortgaging temple lands, thereby ensuring that these properties remained permanently dedicated to religious purposes. In certain cases, lands donated for the maintenance of specific festivals, rituals, or temple feasts were entrusted to a *Kanam* trust. These trusts, generally consisting of several Brahmin families, collectively administered the endowed lands by distributing management responsibilities among their members. This system reflects the highly organised and corporate nature of temple administration in Early Medieval Kerala and illustrates the close relationship between religious institutions, Brahmin settlements, and agrarian society.

Karanmai

The concept of *Kanam* constituted a significant aspect of the land tenure system in Early Medieval Kerala. It referred to a form of perpetual lease that conferred substantial rights upon the holder, including the authority to transfer or sublease the land to another cultivator. Thus, *Kanam* represented an intermediate proprietary right that existed between absolute ownership and cultivation. Based on inscriptional evidence, particularly the Tharisappalli Copper Plates, M. G. S. Narayanan identifies three principal categories of land rights in Early Medieval Kerala: *Kanam* (proprietorship or intermediate ownership), *Karanmai* (cultivating tenancy), and *Kutimai* (occupancy rights). These categories formed the legal framework governing agrarian relations and reflected the hierarchical distribution of rights over land.

The lands administered by the *Uralar* were generally leased to *Karalars*, who held *Karanmai* rights and cultivated the land in return for paying a fixed share of

the agricultural produce as rent. Several inscriptions recording land donations to Brahmin corporations specify that the holder of the *Karanmai* tenancy should be selected by the donor. This provision suggests that *Karanmai* rights were normally hereditary and enjoyed legal protection. Inscriptional records also imposed restrictions on the authority of the *Uralar* in appointing or removing *Karanmai* tenants. They prescribe penalties, including the payment of double fines for delays in fulfilling contractual obligations, and required the surrender of tenancy rights when cultivators were unable to meet the conditions of their tenure. These regulations demonstrate the existence of a well-developed legal system governing tenancy and land management.

In addition to *Uranmai*, *Kanam*, *Karanmai*, and *Kutimai*, another important category of land tenure was *Viruthi* (service tenure). Under this system, specific plots of land were permanently assigned to individuals or families in return for the performance of designated services. These services were usually connected with temples, local administration, or other public institutions. The names assigned to various *Viruthi* holdings often reflected the particular service attached to the grant, illustrating the close relationship between land tenure and occupational responsibilities in Early Medieval Kerala.

The agrarian system of the period was characterised by a clearly defined hierarchy of land rights. At the highest level were the holders of *Kanam* rights, who possessed substantial proprietary interests in the land. Below them were the *Karalars*, who enjoyed hereditary *Karanmai* rights as cultivating tenants and were responsible for agricultural production. At the lowest level stood the *Kutiyars*, who possessed only *Kutimai* or occupancy rights and occupied the most subordinate position within the agrarian hierarchy. Land was regarded as a valuable and secure economic asset, and these interrelated forms of tenure—*Kanam*, *Karanmai*, *Kutimai*, and *Viruthi*—together constituted the foundation of Kerala's traditional landholding system. The essential features of this system

continued with only minor modifications until the Mysore and British periods, when significant changes were introduced in land administration and revenue practices.

Part V

Trade Guilds

Trade guilds played a vital role in the commercial, political, and cultural life of Early Medieval Kerala (c. 800–1200 CE). Benefiting from its strategic location along the Indian Ocean trade routes, Kerala emerged as an important centre of maritime commerce connecting the Arab world, the Persian Gulf, East Africa, and Southeast Asia. The prosperity of overseas trade led to the growth of powerful merchant corporations that organised commerce, regulated trade, and maintained commercial networks across the Indian Ocean.

Among the most prominent merchant guilds were the Manigramam**,** Anjuvannam**,** Valanjiyar, and the Nanadesis**.** Epigraphic records, particularly the Tharisappalli Copper Plates (849 CE)**,** provide valuable evidence regarding the privileges enjoyed by these guilds.

Trade guilds exercised considerable autonomy in managing commercial activities. They regulated trade, maintained warehouses and market centres, collected customs duties, resolved commercial disputes, and ensured the safe movement of merchants and goods. Their activities promoted the export of Kerala's principal commodities, including pepper, cardamom, coconut products, ivory, timber, and spices, while facilitating the import of horses, metals, textiles, luxury goods, and ceramics from West Asia and China. Beyond their economic functions, merchant guilds also contributed to the social and religious life of

Kerala by making donations to temples, churches, and other religious institutions. Their close association with the Chera rulers strengthened political authority and enhanced the prosperity of port towns such as Kollam, Kodungallur, and Vizhinjam.

Valanchiyar

The Valanchiyar were one of the most influential merchant guilds of medieval Kerala and formed an integral part of the wider commercial network of South India. Along with the Nanadesis, they played a significant role in facilitating long-distance trade across the region. Epigraphic evidence indicates that the activities of the Valanchiyar extended throughout Kerala, with inscriptions recording their presence from Vellayani in the south to Eramam in the north. The earliest known reference to the guild appears in the Chokkur Inscription (898 CE)**,** demonstrating that the Valanchiyar had already emerged as an important commercial organisation by the late ninth century. Further references are found in inscriptions from Panthalayani Kollam, Eramam, Alathur, Peruvamba, and Thirunelli, highlighting their widespread presence and sustained influence in Kerala's economic landscape.

The Valanchiyar were not merely traders but constituted a powerful corporate body that exercised considerable economic and social influence in the regions where they operated. Their activities extended beyond commerce to include participation in local institutions and the management of trade-related affairs. Medieval inscriptions from Andhra Pradesh describe these merchants as protectors of the Vīra-Balanja Dharma, reflecting both their commercial importance and their corporate identity. They maintained close associations with the Ayyavole-500 (Ainurruvar), the most prominent inter-regional merchant guild of medieval South India. The Ayyavole organisation incorporated several affiliated merchant groups, including the Ubhaya-Nanadesis**,** Gavaras**,** and

Mummuridandas, which collectively facilitated extensive commercial exchanges across the Indian Ocean and the inland trade routes of the peninsula. Although the precise origins and organisational evolution of the Valanchiyar continue to be debated, epigraphic evidence clearly demonstrates that they formed an essential component of the South Indian mercantile system.

Anchuvannam

Anchuvannam was one of the most influential merchant guilds that flourished in medieval Kerala between the ninth and thirteenth centuries CE. The term *Anchuvannam* is generally believed to have originated from the Persian word *Anjuman* (association or guild), suggesting its close association with West Asian merchant communities. Most historians identify the guild as consisting primarily of Arab, Persian, Jewish, Syrian Christian, and other foreign merchants who were engaged in overseas maritime trade. Its earliest epigraphical reference occurs in the Tharisappalli Copper Plates (849 CE) issued by Ayyan Adikal Tiruvadi, where the guild is mentioned alongside Manigramam as an important corporate body entrusted with protecting commercial privileges granted to the Syrian Christian merchant Mar Sapir Iso.

The commercial activities of Anchuvannam centred on major ports such as Kollam (Quilon), Kodungallur (Mahodayapuram), and other coastal settlements that served as entrepôts in the Indian Ocean trade. The guild specialized in the import and export of commodities such as pepper, cardamom, ginger, coconut products, horses, silk, precious metals, and luxury goods linking Kerala with the Persian Gulf, the Red Sea, and Southeast Asia. Members of the guild enjoyed extensive royal privileges, including tax exemptions, rights over customs collection, hereditary honours, and judicial autonomy, reflecting the Chera state's encouragement of maritime commerce.

Manigramam

The Manigramam was one of the most prominent merchant guilds of medieval South India. The term Manigramam is generally interpreted as a derivative of *Vanik-Gramam*, meaning an organized association or guild of merchants.The earliest reference to the guild in Kerala appears in the Tharisappalli Copper Plates (849 CE)**,** where the Chera ruler Ayyan Adikal Tiruvadi granted extensive commercial privileges to the Syrian Christian merchant Mar Sapir Iso and recognized the authority of both the Manigramam and Anchuvannam in safeguarding these rights. A Tamil inscription discovered at Takua Pa in present-day Thailand and dated to the ninth century CE provides significant evidence for the presence of the Manigramam merchant guild in Southeast Asia. Similarly, the *Viraraghava Grant* mentions Iravi Korththan as the head of the Manigramam guild, indicating that he exercised a monopoly over trade at Kodungallur.

Manigramam was actively engaged in both inland and overseas trade. Its members organized merchant caravans, managed commercial transactions, regulated trade practices, and maintained close links with rulers and temple institutions. The guild enjoyed significant royal patronage, receiving privileges that included tax concessions, protection of commercial interests, and judicial autonomy in matters concerning trade. The guild also collaborated with other merchant organizations, including the Anchuvannam and the Ayyavole Five Hundred (Ainurruvar), facilitating the integration of Kerala into the extensive maritime trade networks of the Arabian Sea, the Persian Gulf, and Southeast Asia.

Part VI

Bhakti Traditions

The Bhakti tradition emerged as one of the most influential religious and cultural movements in South India between the sixth and ninth centuries CE. It emphasized intense personal devotion (*bhakti*) to a chosen deity, primarily Śiva and Viṣṇu, while challenging the exclusive ritualism of Vedic Brahmanism and the growing influence of Buddhism and Jainism. The movement was led by the Śaiva Nayanmars and the Vaiṣṇava Alvars**,** whose devotional hymns, composed in Tamil, made religious ideas accessible to the common people irrespective of caste and social status. These hymns were later compiled into the *Tēvāram*, *Tiruvācakam*, and *Nālāyira Divya Prabandham*, which became foundational texts of Tamil devotional literature. The Bhakti movement received substantial patronage from the Pallavas, Pandyas, and Cholas, contributing to the growth of temple-centred worship, pilgrimage networks, and the institutional expansion of Hinduism in South India. Beyond its religious significance, the Bhakti tradition played a crucial role in the development of regional languages and literature, the consolidation of temple institutions, and the shaping of the socio-cultural and political landscape of early medieval South India.

Temple and Bhakti

The Bhakti movement in South India developed alongside the rise of grand temples dedicated to Shiva and Vishnu. Patronized by kings, local chiefs, and wealthy elites, these temples emerged as major centres of religious worship, cultural activity, and economic administration. Although the early Bhakti movement challenged certain ritual and social barriers by emphasizing personal devotion over birth and status, it gradually became integrated into the existing social order. Nevertheless, its enduring legacy lies in its emphasis on a direct and emotional relationship between the devotee and God, expressed through rich devotional poetry and music that continue to shape the religious and cultural traditions of South India.

Saivism and Vaishnavism

The growth of the Bhakti movement, particularly the worship of Shiva and Vishnu, played a decisive role in the proliferation of temples across early medieval Kerala. Grand temples dedicated to these deities emerged as important centres of religious worship, social interaction, and economic administration. With the increasing popularity of Bhakti and the consolidation of Chera political authority, temple construction received substantial royal patronage.

The establishment and maintenance of temples became an important means through which rulers asserted their political legitimacy and reinforced their authority. Local chieftains and landed elites also participated actively in temple patronage by donating land, gold, livestock, and other resources. Consequently, temples evolved into institutions that linked religious devotion with political power and economic organisation, illustrating the close relationship between Bhakti, kingship, and state formation in early medieval Kerala.

Saivism in Kerala

The South Indian Śaiva Bhakti tradition was propagated primarily by the Nayanars, whose devotional hymns celebrated Shiva as the supreme deity. Important centres of Śaiva worship included Chidambaram, Tiruvarur, and Tiruvanchikkulam, the latter becoming a major centre of Śaivism in Kerala. The spread of the Śaiva Bhakti movement in Kerala was facilitated by the patronage of the Chera rulers, particularly King Rajasekhara (c. 820–844 CE), who is portrayed in literary and epigraphic sources as a devout worshipper of Shiva. The Vazhappalli Copper Plate Inscription, issued during his reign, begins with the invocation *Namasivaya*, reflecting the growing influence of the Śaiva Bhakti tradition from the ninth century onwards. Rajasekhara is traditionally identified

with Cheraman Perumal Nayanar, one of the sixty-three Nayanar saints and a contemporary of the celebrated Bhakti poet Sundaramurti Nayanar. Tradition attributes to him several devotional compositions, including *Ponvannattantadi*, *Tiruvārūr Mummanikkovai*, and *Ādiyula* (also known as *Tirukkailaya Jnana Ula*), which exemplify the devotional ethos of the period.

The promotion of Śaivism was not confined to the Chera monarchs alone. Local chieftains also played an important role in supporting Śaiva institutions. Ayyan Adikal, the ruler of Venad, was a devotee of Shiva and is known from the Tharisappalli Copper Plates to have extended patronage even to Christian and Vaishnava institutions, reflecting the religious pluralism that characterized early medieval Kerala. Epigraphic evidence indicates that several regional rulers patronized Shiva temples during the reign of Bhaskara Ravi Varman, contributing to the expansion of temple networks alongside the territorial growth of the Chera kingdom. Literary sources such as the *Mushikavamsa Mahakavya* further attest to the patronage of Shiva temples by the Mushika rulers of northern Kerala, demonstrating the widespread support enjoyed by Śaivism across different political centres of the region.

Vaishnavism

The Vaishnava Bhakti tradition in South India was propagated by the Alvars, whose devotional hymns were dedicated to Vishnu and his sacred shrines. Collectively, the Alvars composed hymns in praise of thirteen temples in Kerala, thereby integrating the region into the wider sacred geography of South Indian Vaishnavism. In contrast to the earlier spread of Śaivism, the Vaishnava Bhakti movement appears to have gained prominence in Kerala only after the Śaiva tradition had become firmly established. Like the Śaiva corpus, Vaishnava devotional literature was largely temple-centred, celebrating the deity through hymns that exalted the sanctity of major pilgrimage centres.

Important Vaishnava centres associated with the Bhakti tradition included Venkatam (Tirupati), Kanchipuram, Srirangam, Tirumittakkodu, and Muzhikkulam. In Kerala, prominent temples that emerged as centres of Vaishnavism during the early medieval period included the Vishnu Temple at Tirunavaya, the Vamana Murti Temple at Thrikkakara, the Vishnu Temple at Muzhikkulam, the Sree Vallabha Temple at Tiruvalla, the Vishnu Temple at Thrikkodithanam, the Vishnu Temple at Tiruppuliyur, the Parthasarathy Temple at Aranmula, and the Trichambaram Temple at Taliparamba.

Like Śaivism, Vaishnavism flourished under the patronage of the Chera rulers. Among its most celebrated royal patrons was Kulasekhara Alvar, who is commonly identified with the Chera ruler Sthanu Ravi Kulasekhara. He is traditionally credited with composing the Tamil devotional work *Perumal Tirumozhi* and the Sanskrit hymn *Mukundamala*, both of which occupy an important place in the Vaishnava devotional tradition. Another literary tradition identifies Kulasekhara with a Chera ruler who authored three Sanskrit works: the *Champu* poem *Ascharyamanjari* and the plays *Tapatisamvaranam* and *Subhadradhananjayam*. Although these identifications remain the subject of scholarly debate, they illustrate the close association between the Chera court and the growth of Vaishnava literature.

Epigraphic evidence further demonstrates the royal patronage extended to Vaishnava temples in early medieval Kerala. Inscriptions from the Tirunelli Temple record grants of land and other endowments specifically intended for the maintenance and administration of the temple, indicating sustained royal support for Vaishnava institutions. A series of inscriptions from the temple, including some dating to the reign of Bhaskara Ravi Varman, reveal continued patronage by both Chera rulers and regional chieftains. One inscription records a land grant by the local ruler Kunjikkutta Varman, while another refers to a similar donation made by Changarankotha Varman. These inscriptions also mention endowments

made for the support of Alvars and temple functionaries, reflecting the institutionalisation of Vaishnava worship and devotional practices.

Local chieftains likewise contributed to the spread of Vaishnavism. Ayyan Adikal, the governor of Venad, although personally devoted to Shiva, is known to have extended financial support to the Vishnu temple at Kulathur. Such instances demonstrate the coexistence and mutual patronage of both Śaiva and Vaishnava traditions in early medieval Kerala, suggesting that royal and local patronage was often guided more by political and social considerations than by sectarian exclusivity.

The dissemination of Vaishnavism was also facilitated through the public recitation of Sanskrit epics and Puranic literature, particularly the *Mahabharata*. Temple-centred performances and recitations popularised the stories of Krishna and other incarnations of Vishnu, thereby reinforcing devotional practices among the wider population. These literary and ritual traditions played a significant role in integrating Bhakti ideals into the religious and cultural life of early medieval Kerala.

Part VII

Second Chera polity (800-1122 CE)

The Cheras of Mahodayapuram, commonly referred to as the Perumal dynasty of Kerala, represent a crucial phase in the political evolution of early medieval Kerala. Emerging in the ninth century CE, the Mahodayapuram kingdom constituted the first stable and enduring monarchical state in the region. In contrast to the highly centralised political systems of the contemporary Chola and Pandya kingdoms, the Chera state was characterised by a decentralised

administrative structure. Royal authority was exercised through a network of regional chieftains, local assemblies, and autonomous *nadus*, which retained considerable control over local administration. Consequently, the political organisation of the Chera kingdom has been interpreted by historians as a complex and negotiated system in which the Perumal functioned as the paramount ruler, exercising symbolic sovereignty alongside varying degrees of effective political authority over subordinate chiefs. This distinctive political arrangement facilitated the coexistence of strong regional powers within an overarching framework of royal supremacy.

The establishment of the Chera kingdom of Mahodayapuram marked a significant transformation in Kerala's political history. The kingdom flourished from the ninth century until its decline in 1122–1124 CE, providing the region with a relatively stable political order for nearly three centuries. The rulers adopted the title Perumal**,** meaning "the Great One," which signified their exalted royal status and supreme authority. Inscriptions also refer to the rulers as Perumanadikal**,** literally meaning "the feet of the Great One," a title that reflects the reverence and legitimacy associated with kingship. Literary works such as the *Keralolpathi* identify these rulers as Cheraman**,** meaning "the son of the Chera," thereby emphasising their dynastic affiliation and political continuity with the earlier Chera lineage. Epigraphic sources further reveal the use of both conventional and imperial royal titles. Besides the common title Ko (king), the Chera rulers assumed elaborate honorifics such as Rajarajadhiraja**,** Mahodayapuram Paramesvara**,** Ko Konmani Kontan Ko**,** Keraladhinatha, and Chakravarthikal**,** reflecting their aspirations to universal sovereignty and imperial prestige. The royal capital, Mahodayapuram**,** identified with present-day Kodungallur, emerged as the principal political, commercial, and cultural centre of the kingdom.

The mode of succession followed by the Chera rulers of Mahodayapuram remains a matter of considerable historiographical debate. Elamkulam P. N. Kunjan Pillai argued that the dynasty adhered to a patrilineal system of succession, whereby political authority was transmitted from father to son. In contrast, M. G. S. Narayanan has contended that the Perumal dynasty followed the matrilineal (marumakkathayam) principle, under which succession was determined through the female line, consistent with the later social organisation of Kerala. The absence of conclusive epigraphic evidence has prevented the emergence of a scholarly consensus, making the issue of succession one of the most debated aspects of the political history of the Cheras of Mahodayapuram. This debate also highlights the complexities of state formation and kinship practices in early medieval Kerala, where indigenous political traditions interacted with evolving institutions of kingship and regional governance.

Administrative System

The Chera Perumal did not exercise authority in isolation but was assisted by an advisory council known as the Nalu Thali (literally, "the Four Temples"). This unique institution consisted of eight members, with two representatives drawn from each of the four prominent Brahmin settlements of Muzhikkalam, Airanikkalam, Irinjalakuda, and Paravur**,** all located in the vicinity of Mahodayapuram. These Brahmin settlements were associated with four important temples in the capital region, namely Melthali, Kizhthali, Chingapuram Thali, and Neriya Thali**.** The members of this council, known as Thali Adhikarikal**,** functioned as the chief advisers to the Perumal, particularly in matters relating to religion, temple administration, and the management of religious institutions. The prominence accorded to the Nalu Thali demonstrates the close relationship between kingship and Brahmanical institutions in the political structure of early medieval Kerala.

Apart from the Nalu Thali, the Perumal was assisted by a number of high-ranking officials who were responsible for the day-to-day administration of the kingdom. Among these, the Koyil Adhikarikal occupies a prominent place in contemporary inscriptions. This official appears to have served as the principal representative of the king in both administrative and judicial affairs. Epigraphic evidence indicates that the Koyil Adhikarikal presided over village assemblies (*ur*) as well as meetings of temple committees, reflecting the wide scope of their authority. Their position was second only to that of the Perumal, and they acted as the chief intermediary between the central authority and local administrative institutions. The office of the Koyil Adhikarikal illustrates the integration of royal administration with the autonomous local bodies that characterised the decentralised political system of the Chera kingdom.

The military organisation of the Chera kingdom was based on a combination of centralised royal forces and regional military contingents. At the centre was the Ayiram, an elite corps that served as the personal bodyguard of the Perumal and constituted the kingdom's permanent standing force. Complementing this royal army were the militias maintained by individual nadus**,** collectively referred to as the Nattuttayar or regional military organisations. These forces were organised into units such as the Anhuttuvar (Five Hundred), Arunnuttuvar (Six Hundred), and Ezhunnuttuvar (Seven Hundred)**,** which were responsible for the defence and security of their respective territories. This dual military arrangement enabled the Chera rulers to maintain a loyal central force while simultaneously mobilising regional military resources whenever required. It also reflects the decentralised nature of the Chera polity, in which local chieftains retained significant military responsibilities under the overall sovereignty of the Perumal.

Administrative Structure and Local Governance

Epigraphic records reveal that the Chera Perumals maintained a well-developed administrative system supported by a hierarchy of officials. Inscriptions mention functionaries such as the Adhikaran, Padai Nayakan, Menon, and Prakriti, each entrusted with specific administrative, military, or judicial responsibilities. The presence of these officials points to the existence of an organised bureaucracy that assisted the Perumal in the governance of the kingdom. Despite the decentralised character of the Chera polity, the state possessed an effective administrative framework capable of regulating revenue collection, maintaining law and order, and coordinating military affairs. The kingdom also developed a comprehensive taxation system to finance its administration and defence. Inscriptions refer to taxes such as Attaikkol (annual land tax), Rakshabhoga (protection levy), and Aranthai (war tax), in addition to tolls on carts, boats, and commercial transactions involving weighing, measuring, and house construction. Judicial fines constituted another important source of state revenue. Administratively, the kingdom was divided into several nadus, which functioned as semi-autonomous territorial units under the authority of local chieftains. These chiefs exercised considerable control over local administration and retained a significant share of the revenue collected within their jurisdictions. The distribution of judicial fines among the king, local authorities, temples, and other beneficiaries further illustrates the decentralised nature of governance and the sharing of administrative and fiscal responsibilities.

Local self-government formed an essential feature of the Chera administrative system. Urban centres were administered by corporate bodies known as Nagaram, which represented the interests of merchants, artisans, and other urban groups, while rural administration was carried out by village assemblies known as the Ur and the Sabha, the latter functioning primarily in Brahmin settlements. The resolutions passed by these assemblies were known as Kachchams, which possessed legal and administrative validity. A number of such resolutions have

survived in inscriptions, including the Muzhikkalam Kachcham, Kadankattu Kachcham, Thavanur Kachcham, Sankaramangalathu Kachcham, and Kottuvayiraveli Kachcham. Among these, the Muzhikkalam Kachcham appears to have exercised influence beyond its immediate locality, suggesting that it may have served as a model for a wider administrative and legal framework in early medieval Kerala. Together, the institutions of the Nagaram, Ur, Sabha, and Kachcham demonstrate the significant role played by local corporate bodies in governance and highlight the decentralised political structure of the Chera kingdom.

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Multiple Choice Questions

1. Which title was commonly adopted by the rulers of the Chera kingdom of Mahodayapuram?

a) Maharajadhiraja
b) Perumal
c) Gajapati
d) Chakravarti

Answer: b) Perumal

2. The advisory council that assisted the Chera Perumal in religious and temple affairs was known as:

a) Sabha

b) Nalu Thali

c) Nagaram

d) Ur

Answer: b) Nalu Thali

3. The members of the Nalu Thali were known as:

a) Naduvazhis

b) Uralars

c) Thali Adhikarikal

d) Karalars

Answer: c) Thali Adhikarikal

4. Which official acted as the principal representative of the king and presided over village assemblies?

a) Menon

b) Adhikaran

c) Koyil Adhikarikal

d) Prakriti

Answer: c) Koyil Adhikarikal

5. The elite bodyguard of the Chera Perumal was known as:

a) Nattuttayar

b) Ayiram

c) Arunnurruvar

d) Anchuvannam

Answer: b) Ayiram

6. Which of the following was an annual land tax during the Chera period?

a) Rakshabhoga

b) Aranthai

c) Attaikkol

d) Kutimai

Answer: c) Attaikkol

7. The urban administrative body in the Chera kingdom was called:

a) Sabha

b) Ur

c) Nagaram

d) Nadu

Answer: c) Nagaram

8. The resolutions passed by village assemblies were known as:

a) Viruthi

b) Kachchams

c) Kanam

d) Cherikkal

Answer: b) Kachchams

9. Which historian argued that the Chera Perumals followed a matrilineal system of succession?

a) Elamkulam P. N. Kunjan Pillai

b) M. G. S. Narayanan

c) Rajan Gurukkal

d) Kesavan Veluthat

Answer: b) M. G. S. Narayanan

10. The capital of the Chera Perumal kingdom has been identified with present-day:

a) Kollam
b) Kozhikode
c) Kodungallur
d) Kannur

Answer: c) Kodungallur

Short Essay Questions

1. Explain the role and composition of the Nalu Thali in the administration of the Chera kingdom.

2. Discuss the functions of the Koyil Adhikarikal in the Chera administrative system.
3. Examine the taxation system of the Chera Perumal kingdom.
4. Describe the military organisation of the Chera state.
5. Explain the role of Nagaram, Ur, Sabha, and Kachcham in local self-government during the Chera period.

Essay Questions

1. Discuss the political organisation and administrative structure of the Chera Perumal kingdom of Mahodayapuram.
2. Examine the decentralised nature of the Chera polity, highlighting the role of local institutions, bureaucracy, taxation, and military organisation.
3. Analyse the system of local governance under the Chera Perumals with special reference to the functions of the Nalu Thali, Nagaram, Ur, Sabha, and Kachchams.